

TSAR KOR

A Cherdynian Legend

by K. Zhakov

Rendered into English in the manner of the Kalevala

I

The moon, yellow-ochre, rose from beyond the distant mountains of the Stone Belt, and with her light she flooded Iskor, the city perched like an eagle's nest upon a crag unassailable, ringed about at its foot by darkling forests. Grey walls and tall towers at the corners glowed with pale-yellow amber. Spear-points and sabres of the city guard flashed with wandering fires in the rays of the moon ascending from behind the dark hills. Gabled roofs within the city walls likewise were touched by lunar light and cast long shadows upon the silent streets.

Stillness unbroken ruled the town — the people slept in peace, forgetting the joys and labours of their daily life. None awoke when through the transparent glass of windows torrents of moonbeams poured, illuminating floors and walls and white ovens. Only in one high tower burned torches, pouring floods of light upon the mute and empty darkling streets. There a great feast was held: the generous Tsar Kor was treating his beloved ones and the heroes of the people through the night.

At the long table upon pine benches sat his boyars: the glorious Burmat, the famed Kagamort, the brave Porsyor — and beside them the tsar's sons: the elder Redigar, who had travelled through Biarmia, and the younger — the handsome Michamort. Among them, in a red kaftan, sat the red-bearded, mighty Tsar Kor.

Mead with foaming braga passed from hand to hand without ceasing, and after it followed silver ladles with foreign wine. The table groaned with game — gifts of the North: here were birds of every kind — grouse and capercaillie — and fish from the Kama, from the river Vishera and the many-waters of the mountain Pechora: salmon, nelma, sig, pike lay calmly upon the dishes.

In the corner sat a singer, and on a worn dombra he played ancient, stately songs of the heroes of old and the deeds of Tsar Kor.

And the singer sang, playing on the dombra:

*Our mighty one, Kor the Fair,
Hero of the russet beard,
With golden curls he gleams!*

*Once he went to war
Against the Voguls and the Obyr,
Marched to the land of the East,
Countless was our host with him.
They went by river, mountain, pass,
Ever eastward, further to the hills —
Kor sought his enemies there,
Bow and spear in hand he held.*

*Between the blue-grey crags,
Near the rapids, darkling chasms
Of the distant Ural mountains,
He found them, tireless one,
In the dense fir-wood of the Voguls.
He drove them out, the fearless chieftain,
Upon the grey-lichened peaks,
The misty mountains, before Siberia.*

*The hero Ostyak Syamdey,
The Vogul prince Berendelya
Cast their spears at the hero,
Swung their sharp sabres.*

*Yet the Permian warrior did not slumber:
Like a stag he leaped up swiftly,
Like a seal he sprang, the sea-one.
Kor struck the Vogul with his spear,
With a shot he slew the other —
Him who was chieftain of the Obyr*

And tsar of the Ostyak land.

This the moon beheld in heaven,

The sun rejoiced in battle!

The glory of Perm spread abroad

Beyond the blue-grey mountains,

To the golden land of the East.

They submitted to Tsar Kor —

Ostyaks, Voguls, Udmurts.

The Ob-river, the clear Irtysh

And Tobol learned of Perm,

Of the domains of Tsar Kor

At the sources of the bright Kama,

The yellow Vynva, the red Chynva

And other mountain streams,

Known to us, nameless ones,

That flow all to the southern lands

To the Sarydzh sea beyond the plain,

Where flocks of birds are flying

In the dark and rainy autumn.

Thus sang the singer, and the guests listened in silence. Merriment grew at the tsar's feast after the sounds of the dombra and the mighty words of the singer. Mead with white foaming braga and silver ladles with seething foreign wine passed faster from hand to hand. Voices and laughter rose among the feasters.

But now again the singer's voice rang out, and the strings of the dombra sounded:

I shall sing of Redigar,

The tsar's son I glorify!

How he was in a distant land,

In the bright-dawning Biarmia,

Which lies there, at the mouth of the Ezhva,

Where the great Dvina blooms,

Leaning against the shore of the sea,

By the icy waves of the Sarydzh —

There stand the golden cities.

*Our fair Redigar
Went down by the flow of rivers
And reached the bottom of the Dvina,
Obedient to wind and waters.
The white-winged sail of the boat
Bore him to the dark north,
To the geese kaleniks nearer,
To the distant city of Kardor.
Redigar here without fear
Visited Tsar Ramday,
Saw the maiden Taryana —
The tsar's daughter in the pine house.
Sacrifices Ramday brought there
Together with his fair daughter,
Prayed to the god Yomala
For Redigar's health.
He gave his daughter in marriage
To him, to the son of Kor,
Who came from the lands of the East,
From the land of the rosy dawn,
From the blue Kama, from the great mountains.
Her white hand she gave then,
The daughter of Ramday, Taryana,
To Redigar, prince of Perm:
"Thou, my husband, given by fate,
Tarry with us a while —
Until the waning of the maiden moon,
Until the end of the autumn moon,
From the flowering of the earth-berry
Until the time of sweet crowberry,
From the bright-red lingonberry
And the many-coloured cloudberry,*

*That grows in the damp bogs,
Until the flight of heavenly birds,
From the icy waves of the Sarydzh,
Flying away to the warm land,
To the blessed, bright-dawning land.*

*After the flight of the airy birds,
When I shall hear the rush of their wings,
The honking, the cry and the joy —
I shall set forth after thee
To the distant lands of the East
By the waves of the leafy Ezhva,
By the unknown tributaries,
To the land of the Kama, to the city of Iskor."*

And he brought this maiden — Redigar the fair-haired. All marvelled at her beauty.

*"Flower of the Dvina, daughter of Biarmia,
Blue-eyed, white-faced!" —
Thus spoke our wives.
"The lunar sickle alone in the sky,
In the realm of Komi Taryana
Has outshone us all in beauty."*

Thus sang the singer — now falling silent, now again the strings of the dombra trembled in his hands. All were merry, the heroes grew excited, intoxicated by wine and braga.

But among the feasters one did not make merry and did not get drunk — it was the younger son of Kor, Michamort. Long ago the arrow of love had struck him — the bright-rayed son of the sun Shondy-pi. He met in the forest Taryala, daughter of the priest Baramort, and loved her. But Taryala answered not with love — neither tears nor sighs of the tsar's son moved her. This maiden proved more unapproachable and harder than the crag upon which rose the serrated city of Michamort's father.

Tsar Kor, making merry, noticed the pallor of his son, who neither laughed nor boasted of anything at the great feast. He saw sorrow on the face of his son, but delayed to ask the cause — he was not wont to decide quickly, he loved to ponder every word.

Meanwhile the moon rose higher and higher across the sky, painting upon the walls of the tower light and dark figures — shadows of trees and patterns of their branches, forever rustling around the tsar's house.

The feast continued.

Suddenly the doors swung open, and into the feast-hall entered a terrible priest — the servant of the god Voypelya, Baramort himself. He was covered with owl's down, adorned with the furs of sable and ermine; upon him rang iron and copper rings, set into his flesh, with steel knives whose blades flashed in the torchlight.

Removing his fox hat, he bared his grey head to all, raised his hands to heaven and in a thunderous voice spoke:

"Great tsar of many-hilled Perm!

Thy son has dishonoured my daughter this day

Before the rising of the waning moon

In the sacred forest of the god Voypelya.

Son of the north, the threatening wind —

The keen-eared Voypelya has grown wrathful,

And all the gods and goddesses know it!

My evening sacrifice is not accepted by the gods:

The smoke goes not to heaven, but to the valley.

Through the purple flame and transparent waters

Of the sacred vessels in the shrine

I have seen a sorrowful fate

Of our great land —

Defeats and misfortunes of our people.

In all things guilty is thy son Michamort,

He who dishonoured my daughter,

Who broke into my house

In the sacred forest and left her alone without me.

When I returned to the household god — the warshuda,

I met my daughter in tears, in torn garments,

And the criminal had already hidden in the shadows of the sacred trees.

Hasten, Tsar Kor! Propitiate the gods —

Their hatred is terrible to men!

Cease the feast and merriment,

*Hasten to sacrifices and prayers
In the dwelling of the gods...
Behold, behold — disaster comes,
It flies and rushes on black wings!
Delay not the times that wait for no man!"*

Thus spoke the priest Baramort, raising his hands to heaven, rattling his rings and knife-blades. Having spoken all, he left the tsar's house, leaving all in deep silence — as if thunderstruck by the terrible predictions of the dread sorcerer of misfortune for the Permian land.

Tsar Kor sat, leaning upon his mighty arms; his head drooped, his red beard lay upon the table. Michamort looked with frightened eyes at his father, Redigar looked at Michamort, the boyars glanced at one another and were silent.

At last the glorious Burmat, the best of the tsar's warriors, addressed him:

*"Generous Tsar Kor!
We ought not to grieve and suddenly cease the feast.
In vain the priest burst in untimely.
We know not what was — perhaps the old man dreamed all?
For our sorcerer is already very old.
And if Michamort has sinned — be not wroth with him:
He is still too young.
And is the misfortune so great? Is it a wonder that a tsar's son,
Fair as a forest flower,
Dared approach a simple maiden?
The grief is only that this happened
In the sacred forest, full of mysteries and wonders,
Where the old goddess Ibma dwells.
But the gods love Tsar Kor and will accept his sacrifices,
And the goddesses will not be wroth with young Michamort
And will consign to oblivion all that happened before the moon's rising."*

Thus spoke Burmat, and after him all spoke, blaming the priest and excusing Michamort.

Tsar Kor raised his head and addressed the singer:

"Comfort me, inspired singer,

*With the music of mighty songs and sacred words!
Sing to us of the gods and of Great Perm."*

And again sang Vormort, plucking the strings of reindeer sinew:

*Gods terrible in heaven!
Open wide your ears,
Hearken to the sounds of the dombra,
To the sounds of songs sweetly ringing!*

*We conjure — we call you
Not to sorrow, but to joy!
In the pale-yellow lunar light
Put far from us our mortal hour,
Lengthen the threads of our lives —
Soon, soon the days pass
Of man in this world.*

*En — the great one, mother of the sun,
Mother of the moon — she is the godly duck,
That flies in the blue heaven,
And the terrible god, the winged god,
Three-headed, bright-dawning —
The face of the sun, unseen by night,
By day flying above the earth.*

*Downward they gaze from there
Patiently and calmly
Through the crystal of heaven's vaults.*

*Sometimes they scatter snow
Upon our mountains and valleys,
Sometimes they wash
The face of earth with heavenly rain —
So diligently, with love.*

*But judgement and truth on earth
Are wrought by other spirits:
The threatening Voypelya, stately,*

*The mountain whirlwind, keen-eared —
He waits for sacrifices and prayers.*

*Beneath the earth — Kul, the gloomy god:
He receives the shadows of souls,
Prepares the lot for sinners.*

*Mother of the earth — Mumam — nourishes
In this white-black light
All children, little people,
Born of her not without pain
From the spouse — the god of the sun.*

*Our gods love Kor —
The generous ruler
Of all lands along the blue Kama.*

*Grieve not, fierce warrior!
All gods are with thee:
They will turn aside sabre-blows,
They will deflect spear-thrusts,
Fear not the death-dealing arrows —
They will buzz past like bees.*

*Upon the crag thy wondrous city
Is ringed by forest-pass.
No foreigner will dare
Into the land of crags and great mountains,
Of nameless deep rivers,
To bring a host of warriors near.
He will stop afar off,
He will look, wave his hand
And soon turn back,
Frightened by the blue heights,
The gloomy mountains, the roaring streams.*

*Grieve not, beloved Perm!
Thou art shielded from peoples*

*By dark and distant wilderness,
By grey stone and forest,
By patterned slash, trackless ways,
By brief summer, storm's roar,
And by the veil of snowdrifts —
Gloomy, sticky, impassable,
By long winter's foul weather.*

*Dwell in the forests, shine in the mountains,
By the rarely-seen headwaters,
By the winding dark rivers,
By the springs ringing brightly,
By the brooks murmuring in the pass.*

*Of wondrous-secret tales,
Of great, unforgettable deeds
Of the heroes of the forested pass,
Of bright-dawning legends
Of the singing-loud past,
Of bygone song-days —
The trembling of ancient strings
We hear in the spruce forests,
Among branches in the red pine woods,
In the fields, among flowers,
Where camomile and wild rose
Comfort our gazes.*

*Here shine, Perm the Golden!
Strive not for the magic south —
To the north only direct thou
The toes of thy mighty feet!
With thy whole sole walk the passes,
Fear not the grassy tundras,
The icy waves of the ocean —
Our gods have loved
The quiet and beautiful North!*

*They wish not from here
To the east, nor to the west,
Nor to the fire-bright south
To go of their free will
Without the bidding of the higher fate,
Of the world-ruling eternal one.*

Thus played Vormort — ten strings of the dombra loudly trembled. The words of the singer comforted Tsar Kor: he raised his head, began to drink braga, and all followed his example.

The dawn already reddened beyond the mountain 'Polyod', beyond the 'Pomyannaya' and the peak 'Kvorkusha', when the guests dispersed from the house of Tsar Kor. He remained alone with Michamort and asked him of what had happened.

"Two deeds have I done," said Michamort. "One good, the other evil. For the first praise me, for the second punish me.

I was by the leafy headwaters of the river Kolva, between the grey-blue crags. There, high above the river, in a cleft of the rock, I saw a cave — and within, a giant egg. It was laid by the great bird Ryk. It lay like a grey stone on the floor of the dark cave. I stroked it, but did not break it — carefully I went out and blocked the entrance with brushwood and boulders, so that wild beasts and foolish men would not break the egg of the great bird.

From those stony heights I descended by the waves of the swift, many-waters Kolva. Not reaching our rocky city, on the wooded bank I met Taryala by the brook that noisily pours its waters over many-coloured stones into the calmly flowing Kolva.

Long I have loved this maiden. I left the boat — and ran after her. She fled into the dark forest of the terrible Voypelya, the keen-eared god Shua, ran to her father's house and entered it. I followed her — and here I used violence, for longing had driven my soul to despair, and love had clouded my reason.

Having committed the evil deed, I quickly hid behind the trees. And she, standing on the porch, cried out and called for her father.

This is all that happened, my father!

The red-bearded Kor, having heard his son, said:

"Well. Go to sleep. Perhaps the gods will have mercy on us."

Michamort went to his house, and Tsar Kor sat long by the window in his tower, assailed by thoughts and tormented by heavy foreboding. Already the sun had set behind the mountains — behind the blue heads that, like distant clouds, rose in the east — yet the tsar still did not sleep.

"I must propitiate the gods: bring them a black bull, a ram with a white spot, and a golden duck. I must appease the priest — marry his daughter Taryala to Michamort. And strengthen the host that stands in the forests by Iokchi!"

Thus he resolved in his mind, and with this thought he went to rest after the noisy night.

II

No sooner had the time passed that separates the full moon from its waning, than terrible news shook the inhabitants of the city on the high crag: some people were approaching their city — on horseback, armed with bows, cruel and merciless.

Tsar Kor with his sons and boyars went out upon the city walls. From the high tower he saw in the distance warriors in red kaftans, in fur hats — all on swift steeds, armed with long spears and sharp sabres. Spears and sabres flashed in the sun's rays, the crimson kaftans blazed like heat in the fields between the green forests. The unknown people drew near, and the Permian host fled before them.

Two more rows of hills separated the terrible enemies from the city.

Brave Kor — the Permian hero — bade his sons, Burmat and Porsyor, to ride to the Permian host to inspire them to battle in the dark, impassable forests between the hills. He himself looked upon the enemies in bright-red kumach and thought of the defence of the crag and the city of Iskor.

"Will the prophecies of the old priests be fulfilled, who spoke even in my youth: "We are not dwellers here — to the north, to the icy sea, to the grassy tundras must we direct the toes of our feet"?"

Let be what the great gods will! I shall defend myself to my last strength in my stone nest — upon the high crag, above which only kites and hawks do fly.

I shall not abandon it, old raven, without terrible battle — by the rapids, in mountain caves, upon the roofs of towers and houses!"

The Permians, heartened by Redigar and Burmat, entered battle with the countless host of enemies. Redigar, armed with spear and sabre, rode out to the field and challenged one of the warriors in red kaftans to single combat. Towards him rode a man of enormous stature upon a dappled horse. They struck each other with spears — sparks flew from steel chainmail, but the riders remained motionless in their saddles, as if carved from stone. The horses collided so forcefully that both were overturned. Sabres, like lightning, flashed above the heads of the warriors.

In that instant a howl rose in both hosts — cries like thunderclaps shook the air, and echo answered from near and distant forests, from the slopes of the rocky mountains.

The hosts rushed upon each other, as clouds collide in heaven, and arrow-lightnings shook the earth. The ring of chainmail, the whistle of arrows, the clashing of sabres and spears, the neighing of horses, the groans of the dying and the victorious shouts, the crash of falling trees — all filled the fields, riverbanks and forest glades. The sky trembled from battle, the earth groaned, grieving for her children, so fiercely did they destroy one another.

The battle, like fire, quickly spread from the riverbank to the fields and hills, then passed into the forests and virgin glades. Warriors fought at the roots of trees, on branches, even upon the swaying tops.

Tsar Kor watched the battle from the high tower, sending reinforcements to the weakening heroes of Perm. But by the hot noon he saw with sorrow: his host had weakened, the knees of the heroes buckled, arms grew tired of hewing the countless enemies, who multiplied as if springing from the earth. By sunset the remnants of the host, like mice, crept onto the high mountain under the protection of walls and towers, and the unknown enemies surrounded Iskor with a red ring.

Dark night fell. The inhabitants of Iskor lit huge bonfires along the edges of the crag and with weapons in hand awaited the foe. In the distance, in the gloom of the forests, wolves and foxes howled, rejoicing at the corpses of warriors. Above the tops of pines and firs circled black ravens and sharp-eyed kites.

At midnight a cloud covered the city — but it was no cloud, it was the bird Ryk. With her wings she covered the city and in a human voice spoke:

"The times are fulfilled. The unassailable city shall be taken by enemies.

All shall perish — except the inspired singer Vormort,

Tsar Kor the generous, unhappy Michamort and his bride!"

Having said this, the bird lifted from the city — this time not covering it with her mighty wings. Black days came for Perm — days of disaster and unspeakable sorrows.

Tsar Kor did not hasten to decide, but having decided, stood firm. He wished to defend the city while he lived. With the sunrise from all sides upon the crag crept unknown people in red kaftans, in fur hats with red tops. Like swifts, they hid in caves and clefts, clung to cliffs, corners of rocks, dry bushes of juniper.

Kor ordered logs to be thrown upon them, boiling pitch, stones and ashes. With a crash fell upon the enemies' heads giant pines, gloomy firs and white birches. Pitch flowed in fiery streams. The unknown warriors fell from the cliff down — into the stony valley and ravines, like nestlings cast from the nest.

"These are not men," said the chieftain of the red hosts, looking from his golden tent, "but evil gogimagi, driven by the great tsar of Macedon into the stone mountains! What do they want? We shall starve them out — this is a lion's nest!"

And again the broad-faced, narrow-eyed people in kaftans climbed the crag — and again fell into the abyss, stunned by logs.

The siege lasted from the moon's waning to its fullness and again to new waning. The enemies were already weary, begged their chieftain to return to the steppes, to their children and wives:

"Enough have we fought here, in these wild mountains, in empty ravines, where there is neither wealth nor booty! Few people live in this wild, forested place by swift, unfriendly rivers!"

But the chieftain delayed — fate had brought him to the dark northern lands to the simple peoples.

And the Permian singers, standing upon the walls and towers, sang to the warriors:

*Defend great Perm and Kor —
The generous ruler
Of the swift Kama, the bright Kolva,
The many-gifted yellow Vynva!

Great abundant rivers
With white fish, with red fish,
With golden-scaled,
Yellow-finned, silver ones!

Marksmen — be valiant!
Draw your bows:
The twang of the bowstring is so sweet,
The buzzing of the arrow is delightful!*

*Defend the land of squirrels,
Red and fluffy ones,
Of ermine and foxes,
The land of mountains and transparent rivers,
Where freely fly
All godly birds in the dark passes —
The grey grouse, the sleepy capercaillie,
The flocks of gentle pigeons!*

*Help shall come to you from the east,
A host shall rush from the west!
Fear not, children of Perm —
Pleasant it is to die at home,
To lay down one's head for the city
Where you lived so happily,
Where you spent golden days,
Enjoying the ringing of songs,
The emerald of winter tales
And the topaz of bright rays,
The sayings, folk words
And tales of bygone days!*

*Your wives, your little children
Beg and pray you for the same.*

*Clouds of arrows are not terrible to the pass —
Sabres do not take its brave ones,
Spears are terrible only to cowards!*

*Fear not the narrow-eyed,
The yellow-faced strangers,
Warriors in red kaftans!
Rain shall come — and cease,
The black day shall turn to bright,
So too shall the battle fall silent —
The locust, having eaten the bread,*

Shall depart again to the south!

Be bolder, tsar's warrior,

Turn aside the blows of fate!

Thus we sing the songs of battle,

We sing the sweetness of death!

Defend, protect

Great Perm and Kor —

The wondrous city, the high house,

The beacon of many-glorious Perm!

Fear not the enemy's intrigues —

Let them not enter, yellow-faced ones,

Narrow-eyed strangers

Into this many-coloured city,

Into the tower with the purple roof!

And beneath the canopy of our shrines

The gods of heaven will not permit

The enemies of Perm to overcome you!

Thus be valiant, children of Komi!

Protect, defend

Great Perm and Kor!

Thus sang the singers, rousing the people to battle. The priests read conjurations, uttered black, destructive spells, calling upon the gods of heaven and earth.

After their incantations from heaven poured a mighty downpour. Streams and mountain springs overflowed their banks, swept hills into dark valleys — straight upon the host of foreigners. They fled far from the city, and the rivers drove after them with muddy, wrathful waves.

The bird Ryk sat upon the peak of the Ural mountains and looked at the sky, awaiting the decision of the great god Enmar — master of mortals and immortals: shall Perm perish or be saved?

The father of heaven and earth was silent, reading the golden book of fates of kingdoms and peoples, of the past and the future.

Then the bird Ryk spoke:

*"Great God, sitting in the golden palace upon the iron roof of heaven!
Shall my prophecies not come to pass? Shall thy decrees be scorned? Does
the heavenly book write falsely of the affairs of mother-earth?"*

Hearing the words of the great bird, Enmar resolved to give the city to sword and flame — such was his will, such were the writings of the heavenly book.

The downpour ceased. From the clouds descended upon the earth the many-coloured rainbow Ogka-Megika. She, stretching her long neck, plunged her head into the streams and drank all the waters of rivers and brooks. The green plains were bared, and the enemies in kumach garments returned to the city.

In the dark autumn night, when the Permians least expected them, they scaled the walls. The city walls were taken, the towers were shattered by rams, the city was engulfed in flames.

Tsar Kor and his host still fought upon the roofs at the entrance to the high shrines... But one by one the Permians fell from sabre-blows. The final hour came for the city. Upon the high crag kites already pecked at nestlings in the very nest.

Together stood Kor and Michamort, and behind them — the bright singer Vormort, trembling, with dombra in hand. The tsar still raised his sword high and struck the heads of enemies surrounding the tower, and Michamort aided him.

But suddenly a cloud covered them — the bird Ryk swooped down and took upon her back Michamort, Tsar Kor and the inspired musician Vormort.

High rose the great bird and, like morning dawn, flew over enemy heads, over crags and forests. Only flying over the sacred forest of the god Voypelya, she spread her wings like two white clouds, descended to the dwelling of the priest and took upon her back Baramort and his fair-haired daughter Taryala — for the sowing of future tribes.

To the north flew the mysterious bird Ryk — to the headwaters of the Vycheгда. There, upon the high mountain with blue, forested summit — Dzhiedzhim-parma — she laid down the people she had carried from the great Kama: Tsar Kor, Michamort, Taryala, Vormort and the priest Voypelya.

*"Here shall you live," she said. "Look to the north — to the sea of plains!
Live — until the icy waves of the ocean!"*

Having said this, with a noise like rain and storm, she rose into the blue fields of heavenly spaces and through the blue air flew to the heights of the distant Ural mountains.

EPILOGUE

They lived in a hut upon Dzhiedzhim: Tsar Kor and Michamort with his Taryala. With them were the priest and Vormort — singer of the forests.

Kor advised Michamort to gather the people living by the banks of the yellow Vycheгда, to build a city in the pass, to levy tribute upon all natives drinking water from the tributaries of the Vycheгда, and to create a strong kingdom in the forest glades.

But to them came a grey old man — whether god or forest spirit, none knew — and said:

"We need no host, we need no kingdom. We live here freely, as forest beasts, as birds of the air. Southern peoples, devouring all — grain, beasts, stone ores — march northward. But they shall not soon come to us. While we live in freedom — children of great En!"

Having said this, he vanished.

Michamort obeyed him. Tsar Kor, longing for the blue Kolva and his city — the stone nest — soon died in the pass beneath a tall fir. Thus ended his days.

And Michamort lived a new life — emulating fish and birds, and not the southern, predatory peoples who themselves suffer and give no peace to others at the edges of the world.

The singer Vormort walked through the forests, sang and lamented, playing on the dombra:

*Dread and terrible has happened —
The bird Ryk has carried us
Over mountains, rivers, valleys
To the distant land, to the north,
To the sandy banks of the Ezhva,
To the summit of Dzhiedzhim-parma.

I weep, I weep for the Kama —
The bright river softly flowing!
Rivers of tears I shed
For the past, for the great,
For the bright-rayed kingdom of Kor,
For the dark-pined crag!*

*Many-coloured, unbeholden —
Where art thou, where art thou, city of Iskor,
Unequalled in the East,
Emerald among misty mountains,
Among dark-coloured stones
Thou shonest like bright topaz!*

*Precious jewel in the wilderness,
Heart of life, bright city —
They have turned thee to ash,
Evil people, those southerners!..*

*Bird, I weep, lonely one,
Rivers of tears I shed
For thee, my beloved Iskor!
Never shall I forget
Thy bright, radiant image.*

*I shall sing the glory of Perm,
I shall proclaim the valleys, mountains!
The sounds of the dombra shall resound here
As a lesson to distant peoples
And to descendants for admonition:
How suffered our great Kor
For distant glory —
The city was taken for the same,
For brides of future generations,
That their strings might tremble,
That songs might be heard
Of the past glory of Komi,
Of great and terrible deeds —
Ununderstandable to descendants!*

*Dark passes, hear ye
My groans, songs of the dombra!
My tears convey ye
To all future generations —*

*Forget nothing:
Of the great deeds of Kor,
Of the sufferings of proud Perm!
I weep and am unconsolable,
Rivers of tears I shed...*

Thus sang the singer — and his words were preserved in the dark passes, in the bright pine woods, in the song of birds, in the rustling of forests.

From them did I learn this old legend of Tsar Kor.

K. Zhakov

First published in Nos. 51, 56, 59 and 61 of

"Arkhangelskaya Gubernskaya Vedomosti", 1911